

HOW (NOT) TO READ THE BIBLE · SESSION 1

Never Read a Bible Verse

Reading Scripture in context, the way it was written

ICEBREAKER

Where have you seen these verses?

Philippians 4:13

"I can do all things through him who strengthens me"

Jeremiah 29:11

"Plans to prosper you and not to harm you"

Matthew 7:1

"Judge not"

Matthew 18:20

"Where two or three are gathered"



Video: Session 1

Jot notes on the front of your handout as you watch

VIDEO DEBRIEF

Talk it over

1. What does "never read a Bible verse" mean, and what doesn't it mean?
2. What example of a misread verse stuck with you? What went wrong?
3. The Bible was written **for** us, not **to** us. Say it in your own words.
4. Why does the Bible's big story matter for the hard passages ahead?

THE BIG IDEA

**A verse means what its author meant
in its context.**

THE METHOD

Three circles of context

1. Literary

The paragraph and book around it. What kind of writing is it?

2. Historical

Who wrote it, to whom, when, and what were they facing?

3. Big story

Creation → Fall →
Redemption → Restoration.
How does it point to Jesus?

THE METHOD

Three steps, always in this order

Observe

What does it say? Who, what, when, repeated words, "for," "therefore," "but."



Interpret

What did it mean to them?
What timeless truth does it teach?



Apply

How should that truth change what I believe, love, or do?

WORKSHOP · PASSAGE 1

Philippians 4:10–20

Observe

- Why is Paul writing? (vv. 10, 14–18)
- Where is he? (1:7, 13)
- What are the "all things"? (v. 12)
- What has Paul learned? (v. 11)

Interpret

- In context, what does Christ strengthen Paul to do?
- What's the timeless truth?

WORKSHOP · PASSAGE 2

Jeremiah 29:1–14

Observe

- Who wrote this, and to whom? (v. 1)
- What are they told to do? (vv. 5–7)
- How long until the promise? (v. 10)
- What were false prophets saying? (vv. 8–9)

Interpret

- Who is the "you" in verse 11?
- What's the timeless truth about God?

REPORT BACK

Alone vs. in context

Verse	Alone it seemed to say...	In context it says...
Phil 4:13	I can achieve any goal	Christ makes me content in plenty or want
Jer 29:11	My personal plans will succeed	God will restore his people, on his timeline

THIS WEEK

Read the chapter, not just the verse

- Pick a verse you've leaned on and read its whole chapter
- Try one take-home passage on your handout
- Next week, *Stranger Things*: skim Leviticus 19 before you come

"Open my eyes, that I may behold wondrous things out of your law." Psalm 119:18